

VertiGO!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 689 June 2006 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Astoria Cafe, Lambton Quay at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards.

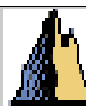


June 12th Section Night – Photo Competition

Shaun Barnett will judge the annual photo competition. By the time you get this edition of VertiGO, Shaun will be busy judging the quality and impact of the photos that have been entered in this year's competition. There are six separate categories in which photos are judged: alpine nature, alpine activity, alpine general, rock climbing, humour and photo-journalism. Come and see some stunning pictures! Come and learn how to take better photos! Some fantastic prizes to be won!



Andy Flat - Olivines



Section trips news

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.



Adventure In The Darrans

Richard Thomson, with Dave Vass and Richard Turner, lucked in with a week-long fine spell in the Darrans back at the end of March. They walked up the Donne valley towards the Central Darrans and, after a few scary false leads, ferreted a route around the true left edge of the Taoka Icefall to reach Patuki Col and Lake Turner.

Once there they ensconced themselves under a splendid rock overhang at just under 2000m, looking out over the lake towards the peaks of Tutoko and Madeline. This bivvy is half way along a ledge system, with cliffs above and below. It has room for four in comfort and permanent running water, although its altitude and north facing aspect mean taking a tent or tent fly would be advisable.

The bivvy was discovered by Richard Turner and named Turner's Eyrie, in keeping with the names of many of the nearby features. While there they climbed a new six-pitch rock route on the northwest flank of Karetai: Statue Bro? grade 19. They attempted another route on the other side of the basin, but had a hard time finding any runners, and retreated to make a high-level circumnavigation (the only possible kind) of Lake Turner. En route they used some surplus fuel to re-enact the Balrog scene from The Lord of the Rings, with a flaming trundle into a spectacularly deep dark cleft. A rest day was spent climbing Karetai. Then, after checking the feasibility of a descent from the head of the Taoka snowfield into the Kakapo basin (where the last mainland kakapo were discovered in the 1970s - and no, it wasn't feasible) they returned back down the Donne happy but completely wrecked!

Richard Thomson



Olivines By Compass

Warrick Hill, Don McKay, Toby Johnston and Don French has 12 days enjoying rain in south westland.

They completed a traverse, by compass, of the Olivine Ice Plateau in poor conditions. Route was up 10 hour gorge, the Williamson, Andy Flat, and gained the Plateau via a route using the tussock slope to the TL of the Andy courier (good travel). The parties ambitions plans where severely hampered by the weather and they where forced to retreat via the Forgotten, Olivine & Beans Burn rivers. One day all will return to see the view.

Don French



Eiger Dreams

Bernese Oberland, Switzerland: Rob McBrearty and John Nankervis joined Kiwi expats Jamie Durham and Paul Lynch in Grindelwald just after Easter for some ski mountaineering. After a couple of de-lagging and acclimatising days, spent skiing at Kleine Scheidegg below the North Wall of the Eiger and on the Schilthorn in the Lauterbrunnen, they skied into the Aletsch Glacier from the Jungfrauoch rail station. Based at the Concordia, Finsteraarhorn and Hollandia huts they made ski ascents of the Louwitor, Trugberg, Kranzberg, Wyssnollen, Finsteraarhorn (the monarch of the Oberland), Gross Wannenhorn and Abeniflue. The last of these preceded a wonderful 2,200 meter descent of the Lotschental to the village of Fafleralp. The weather was mainly good and the snow predictably variable.

John Nankervis



Summer Skiing on Ruapehu

During the third weekend of February Chris Newton and Mike Peat headed up to Ruapehu for a weekend of fun in the sun. Friday evening was spent in Taihape with a friend of Mike's tucking into a hearty farm dinner and a late night single malt whiskey session. Tired but keen we got up at 4am the next morning despite having only retired three hours earlier! By 6am the sun was rising over the Kaimanawas behind us revealing a cracker day as we lugged our skis up through the Tukino skifield. We were able to skin from just below Buttons Buttress and continued up the couloir between the buttress and the Thumb before traversing out of the gully at its head gaining the plateau at the head of the Mangatoetoenui Glacier. After a brief spell, we continued across the plateau, skirting round the Dome and up the east ridge of Paretetaitonga. A glorious run was had from the summit 600m down the Whangaehu Glacier to where the snow gave way to glacial ice. Skins were fixed and we headed back up and across the plateau for a final ski run down the Mangatoetoenui Glacier and a walk to the car. The afternoon was spent having a siesta on the Chateau golf course – to the amusement of a group of golfers looking for a stray ball. We rounded our trip off by spending Sunday rock climbing at Meadsw Wall and the Whakapapa Gorge where Chris led several nice routes while Mike seconded in poor style.

Mike Peat



Autumn Ice on Ruapehu

After several aborted attempts Chris Newton and Mike Peat finally managed to get away to Ruapehu on the third weekend of May for a taste of early season ice. An enjoyable meal and a pint of Guinness was had watching the Hurricanes take out their semi-final at the Whakapapa Tavern before we shouldered our packs for the walk up to Whakapapa Hut on Friday night. On Saturday we soon discovered that despite the good snow cover (skiing is possible to the carpark) the usual places were wanting for ice which limited our options. Classic drainage lines such as Chiming Bells and Gorilla were too thin and the Broken Leg Gully waterfall was just that! We spent a good amount of time scaring ourselves soloing short badly exposed routes on unreliable ice in Great Gully, but Comfortably Numb and Momentary Lapse of Reason on the Pink Floyd Buttress were enjoyable outings. A lot of fun and laughter was had confirming our lack of gymnastic prowess on a number of mixed bouldering problems at Delta Corner.

Mike Peat



WELLINGTON . AUCKLAND

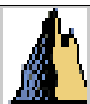
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Section General News



Aspiring Documentary on TVNZ – Queen's Birthday.

An evocative new documentary filmed on and around Mt Aspiring will screen on TV One on Sunday June 4th.

Including extremely rare footage of the Matukituki Valley and Aspiring Hut, the documentary tells the story of four of NZ's greatest artists and their attempt to make a highly creative film about an ascent of the SW Ridge. Producer is Wellington section member, Gary Scott, from local company The Gibson Group.

It is a real tale of forgotten silver. Not only are the four artists legends in their own right – poet James K Baxter, composer Douglas Lilburn, photographer Brian Brake and painter John Drawbridge – but the climbing team they worked with included George Lowe, Ed Cotter and Harry Stevenson.

They were young men in 1949. Their ideal was to make a new kind of film - not the standard news reel but a poetic tribute to New Zealand and the iconography of the mountains. Famously, Baxter wrote Poem In The Matukituki Valley while he was there. Island Bay artist John Drawbridge returned to the valley during filming.

Typically, the weather didn't help and the trip seemed to end in disaster, although the climbing team did sneak up for one of the earliest ascents of the SW Ridge.

"But then the footage disappeared" says Scott, "and that's the intrigue behind the documentary. It has a pretty dramatic ending."

Aspiring will screen on TV One, in Artsville, Sunday June 4th at approx 10:30pm. Send any queries to aspiring@gibson.co.nz.



NZAC Wellington Section 2006 Photo Competition

ENTRIES CLOSE: Friday 2nd June however late entries may be accepted (depending upon how late!).

Entries will be accepted in six categories; Alpine Activity, Alpine General, Alpine Nature, Rockclimbing, Humour, Photo Journalism.

This year we have a new judge, Shaun Barnett. Shaun is well known for his outdoor photography and was the former editor of Wilderness Magazine.

We are also pulling together a great range of prizes.

Get your entries into Mainly Tramping in the Grand Arcade or email your digitals to james.wright@telecom.co.nz

Details, competition rules and entry form available at nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.

imagelab



Tongariro Guidebook

Richard Thomson will be doing a brief presentation on the brand new Tongariro Guidebook and copies will be available after the meeting for the special members only price of \$25. This publication has to be a "must" for every aspiring North Island iceclimber this winter. Now's your chance to get in early!

The great peaks of the central volcanic plateau are a treasure house for climbers and skiers. Their summits are the North Island's premier alpine wilderness; many North Island climbers first learned their craft here, whether on ice, rock or snow. This guide spans the range of climbing opportunities Tongariro national Park provides. Ruapehu, especially, is world-famous as a skier's mountain, and opportunities for ski-mountaineering away from the big fields are described. But it is also the first ever detailed guide to alpine routes and technical ice climbs. The rich tradition of rock climbing in the park is celebrated, from the early twentieth century pioneers on Holl's Rock to modern test pieces in the Whakapapa Gorge. The book is illustrated with images from some of New Zealand's top outdoor photographers, and topographical maps and photo-topos show the routes in detail. Whatever kind of climbing adventure you are planning in the national park, this book will provide information and inspiration.

For Sale



Scarpa Vega plastic boots with 'high altitude' inner. UK size 10, excellent condition as only used a few times. \$250 or near offer.

Rab Andes Down jacket. Size XL, blue with black reinforced sections in arms and shoulder, pertex outer, box wall construction, 96% Goose down fill (750+EU 850+US), detachable hood. Excellent condition & seriously warm. \$250 or near offer.

Feel free to arrange a time to try the boots or jacket on.

Contact: Chris Newton, 021 261 8605 / 04 499 1093 / chrisnewtonuk@hotmail.com



AIC 2006 – Only 2 spots remain!

The planning and organising for the Alpine Instruction Course 2006 is well underway.

Dates are:

Theory 1: Tuesday July 4 (evening) Wellington

Weekend 1: 8-9 July Mt. Ruapehu

Theory 2: Tuesday July 18 (evening) Wellington

Weekend 2: 22-23 July Mt. Ruapehu

Theory 3: Tuesday August 1 (evening) Wellington

Weekend 3: 5-6 August Mt. Taranaki

The cost is \$760 and participants will need to be members of the New Zealand Alpine Club (See www.alpineclub.org.nz for info).

Please contact:

Caroline Duggan, cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz OR

Matthew Stevens, ms@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

for more information.

[NB: There is still space for section members who are interested in being instructors on the course. Training and support is given to new instructors. Contact Caro/Matthew as well....]

Distaghil Sar Dinner

"We are proposing to have the Distaghil Sar Fund dinner on Thursday 24 August, at Turnbull House. We will keep the price low, but some of the proceeds will go to the Distaghil Sar fund. This year's grants from the fund will also be announced at the dinner

Put the date in your diary now!"



Avalanche Stage 1

This training and assessment course covers all the theory and practical skills involved in avalanche safety. Stage 1 is requirement for employment in many areas of the ski industry and in alpine recreation and instruction. This is a 7 day intensive live in course on Mt Ruapehu starting 20 August.

Enrolments accepted now. Closing date for enrolments 24th July

Enquire: 04 238 2310
w.putt@whitireia.ac.nz
www.whitireia.ac.nz
WHITIREIA COMMUNITY POLYTECHNIC
0800-944-847



Homer Hut Opening

The renovated Homer Hut on the Milford Road was officially opened by the Southland section on May 6. This alpine club hut is now a fantastic asset and is a big improvement on the previous facilities. It boasts a fully insulated sleeping area, a comfortable (and toasty warm) living area with great cooking facilities, and a first class warden's quarters complete with a hot shower. The opening was a celebration of the Southland section's commitment to the project, and the long hours of volunteer work that went into the refurbishment. A number of key people

involved in the project spoke about its history, including a longstanding member of the club who shared his memories of building the original hut. The reigns were then handed to National President, Judy Reid, who after a short speech, cut the official ribbon. The Southland section expressed thanks to the Wellington section for their financial support of the project and encouraged their northern counterparts to make the journey south to take advantage of the hut....and if you are interested in hooking into the hot shower, keep an eye out for the hut warden opportunities.



Ground Floor, Grand Arcade, 16 Willis Street, Wellington
Ph/Fax 04 473 5353, PO Box 1560, Wellington
email: mainly.tramping@paradise.net.nz
www.mainlytramping.co.nz



Update of Section Website

The wellington section website will be getting a face lift and an update of content over the next few months. We are looking for volunteers with suitable web expertise to assist the project team with this task. The website is a key point of contact for people wanting to know more about the club and about current activities. The update will ensure that the most up to date information is available and easy to find, and also appealing to look at. Any assistance that can be provided will be very gratefully received. Please contact Jen Brown (JB2@...)

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to Caroline Hart (trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz). Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

See you in the hills!

China Trip

At present there's not enough interest in this trip to make it worthwhile. For the peak fee, the optimum number is 10, and if we could get close to this, we would be happy to get back to the agents in China with a firm proposal. But time is running out for a 2006 climbing trip.

The high trekking option is still open, and can be arranged at shorter notice.

Contact china@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, or betts@paradise.net.nz or j-reid@paradise.net.nz. Check our section website for pics and information."

We have a likely venue to consider, and also some quotes from local agents. Including air fares, the cost for a 3-week climbing trip looks as if it will be somewhere between \$5000 and \$6000. If you're interested and want to hear more, we look forward to seeing you at the meeting.

Mt Ruapehu Ice Climbing

15-16 July, Whakapapa

There has been a lot of interest and I'm expecting there will be a big turnout. As such the venue has changed (originally we were looking at going to Tukino Ski field) - now we are going to Whakapapa instead to make use of the NZAC hut at Delta Corner. The main ice climbing wall we hope to use is the Barium Enema Face, about 45 minutes walk from the hut. The Pinnacles can be used as a back up option. If there is a major storm hitting the mountain then the reserve date is 22-23 July. I'll email any cancellation.

The trip is really just a bunch of people getting together to go climbing. There will be climbers already adept on ice and climbers having their first climb - a range of climbs will be set up to cater for all. I hope to get perhaps five climbs set up at any one time, most top rope but some sport climbs also. I'm wanting to get a couple of instruction "workshops" running too - lead climbing, leash less tool climbing, etc.

Also the weekend will help as a trial run (or a learning experience) for a more official ice climbing festival in 2007 with organisers not having to work out all aspects of a proper event first time up.

Climbing will commence on Saturday morning and are planned to continue into Saturday night due to short winter days. Then climbing continues on Sunday morning and finish mid afternoon.

Contact: Caroline Hart ch@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz

Mt Ruapehu Ski Touring

10-11 July

Kristen Foley is organising a ski touring trip. If you are interested, you can contact Kristen on kf@nzalpine...

Wye Creek Ice Climbing

August

Toby Johnston is organising a general alpine trip with ice climbing and ski touring options in August. The trip will be to Wye Creek in the Remarkables or to Black Creek as a second option. For further details contact toby@basecampwanaka.co.nz

Aconcagua expedition

The highest mountain in the Southern Hemisphere and outside Asia is the perfect choice to take your high altitude trekking to the next level. I'm organizing an Aconcagua expedition between 11/2006 and 02/2007 or 11/2007 and 02/2008 and I'm looking for people to join the core group to work out the details during the next few months. Once the exact budget, date, route and timetable have been set the expedition will be open for any club members to join at a later phase. Aconcagua does not necessarily require technical climbing skills but experience in high altitude trekking and fitness is required. For those who aim on taking eight-thousanders later Aconcagua is extremely good practice. I am also considering combining an acclimatisation trip to the Cotopaxi (and possibly the other volcanos there) in Equador just before the expedition.

Please contact me through e-mail at jsarkila@gmail.com for more information and visit www.aconcagua.com for general information about the mountain.

Juho Sarkila
Wellington

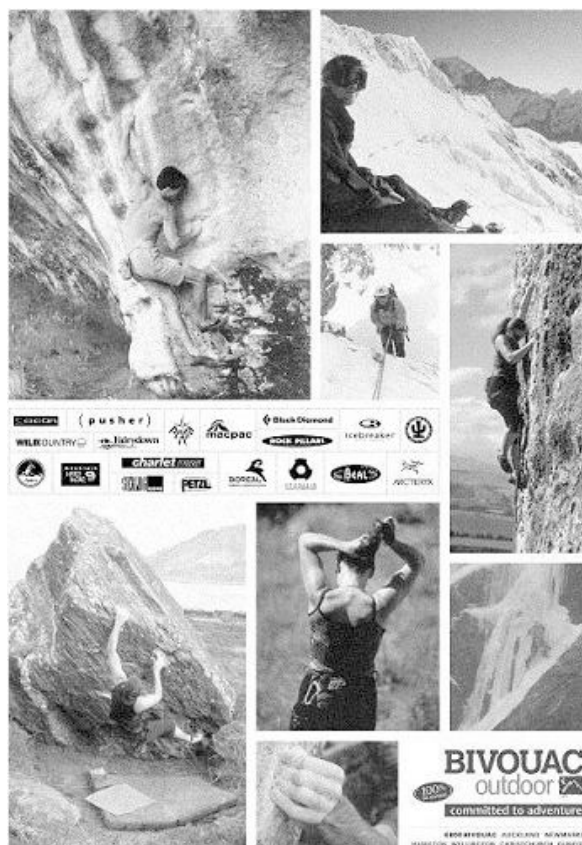


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Banff Success Again!

The 2006 edition of the Wellington Section Banff International Mountain Film Festival was again a great success. The funds raised topped \$6000 and will contribute to the refurbishment of the Unwin Hut and eventually Delta Ridge Hut.

Any and all feedback that will contribute to making Banff 2007 even better is greatly accepted. Please send to md@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz.

Rumours about that Icebreaker may be contributing a large amount of spot prizes for next years event. Stay tuned.



Mt Kau Kau – Killer Mountain!

Earlier in the month, our much loved (and cuddly) section Chairperson was injured attempting a daring solo traverse of the high style near the summit on the east face of the coveted Mt Kau Kau. After bravely crawling from the exposed fence style to the relative safety of the summit, the ambulance ride ensured a safe return.

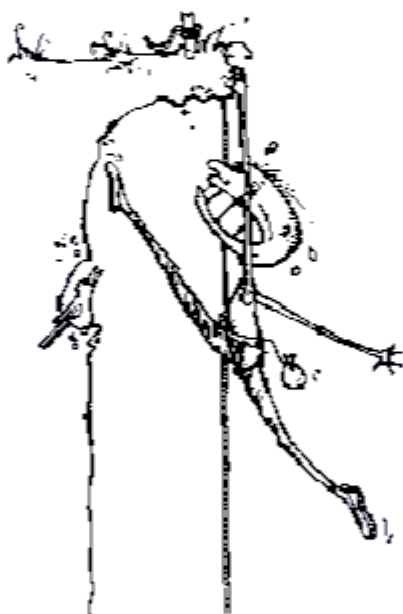
Get well soon Garth.
Ed.



Section Directory

Position	Name	E-mail Alias*	Phone
Patron			
Chairperson	Garth London	CHAIRPERSON <i>or</i> GL	(04) 479 2984
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Secretary	Rachel Depree	SECRETARY <i>or</i> RD	N/A
Treasurer	Karen Domaneschi	TREASURER <i>or</i> KD	(04) 475 8453
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	Garth London	GL	(04) 475 7543
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Instruction: RIC	Blair Hiscoke	SPRINGROCK	N/A
Trips	Merewyn Ellis	ME	N/A
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
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	Hayden Cox	HC	(04) 9763365
	Kristen Foley	KF	N/A
	Paul Grimwood	PG	N/A
	Caroline Hart	CH	N/A
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	Amanda Redvers	AR	N/A
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National President	Judy Reid	JR	N/A

- Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



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